Pause and Fix

Responding to a common misconception

Use Pause & Fix when a common gap means continuing would reinforce an error or make the next step inaccessible. Stop briefly, repair the precise issue and return to a fresh attempt.

How to do it well

1 Identify the common gap. Use responses or work to locate the knowledge or decision causing widespread difficulty.

2 Stop and frame the repair. Secure attention, name the issue neutrally and explain why this short pause matters.

3 Re-model differently. Use a smaller step, contrasting example or clearer representation that addresses the error directly.

4 Give a fresh check. Require every student to apply the idea to a related example before you reveal the answer.

5 Resume proportionately. Continue when the evidence supports it, with targeted follow-up for remaining gaps; extend the repair when the class is still insecure.

What this sounds like

“Pause. Several answers use the mass in place of the volume. We will model that distinction once, then everyone will try a new example.”

Classroom example. In Maths practice, several pupils apply the same invalid cancellation. The teacher stops, identifies the exact condition for a valid move and contrasts the two cases. Everyone then attempts a new item. Once the class pattern is secure, practice resumes with individual follow-up for remaining gaps rather than a complete restart of the topic.

Top tips that make the technique work

Pause for a consequential pattern. A few isolated slips may need individual feedback rather than stopping productive class work.

Change the explanation. Repeating the same long account more loudly rarely addresses the faulty idea.

Keep the repair bounded. State the specific distinction you are fixing and show it with one clear example.

Keep secure students thinking. Ask them to explain the misconception or test a useful variation rather than sit through unnecessary repetition.

Recheck before resuming. Use changed surface details and the same conceptual demand so students must apply the repair.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Match the repair to the shared error.	Stopping the class for every interesting error.
Secure attention before re-explaining.	Treating copied corrections as proof the issue is fixed.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

Barton - A model for responsive teaching | DistillED - Adaptive Teaching